

**WASHINGTON, DC CIVIC JOURNEY · 8TH GRADE CIVICS · APRIL 14 TO 18, 2027**

Educational Journey

Teacher and student pages for Democracy in Place: the inquiry question, the fourteen sites day by day, the learning at every site, and the field journal and assessment guide students carry from site to site.

INQUIRY	SITES	LEARNING LEAD	FINAL RESPONSE DUE
How does a democracy decide, preserve, include and remember?	Fourteen over three days	Olivia Bennett 216-555-0158	Friday April 30

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Democracy in Place

One question, fourteen sites, three days of evidence. The next three pages walk through the sites day by day; students answer the question after the trip with evidence from at least three of them.

How does a democracy make decisions, preserve evidence, include voices and remember its past?

Institutions and power

Thursday. The National Archives, the U.S. Capitol, the Library of Congress and the Supreme Court: how law is made, recorded, interpreted and made available to the public.

Rights and voices

Friday. The National Museum of African American History and Culture and the National Museum of American History: how objects and testimony expand, challenge and deepen the national story.

Memory and leadership

Friday evening and Saturday. Four memorials, Arlington National Cemetery and the National Portrait Gallery: how design, ritual and portraiture say what a nation values.



- 1 National Archives · Thursday 9:30 a.m. · educator-led program and the Rotunda
- 2 U.S. Capitol · Thursday 1:00 p.m. · tour and Exhibition Hall
- 3 Library of Congress · Thursday 2:30 p.m. · Great Hall and reading-room overlook
- 4 Supreme Court · Thursday 3:45 p.m. · from the plaza
- 5 National Museum of African American History and Culture · Friday 10:00 a.m.
- 6 National Museum of American History · Friday 2:15 p.m.

- 7 World War II Memorial · Friday 6:30 p.m.
- 8 Vietnam Veterans Memorial · Friday evening
- 9 Lincoln Memorial · Friday evening
- 10 Korean War Veterans Memorial · Friday evening
- 11 Arlington National Cemetery · Saturday 8:30 a.m.
- 12 National Portrait Gallery · Saturday 1:00 p.m.
- 13 Lafayette Square · Saturday 3:15 p.m.
- 14 White House · Saturday, from Pennsylvania Avenue

What students bring home: one primary-source analysis, one institution diagram, one voice-and-evidence pair, one object comparison, one memorial design comparison, one private reflection from Arlington, one portrait analysis, and a final argued response or exhibit pitch that uses evidence from at least three sites.



Washington, DC
April 14 to 18, 2027

Thursday: Institutions and Founding Evidence

The founding documents at the National Archives in the morning, then Capitol Hill: the Congress that works under them, and the library and court that stand beside it.



Thursday, April 15 • numbered in visit order Mapbox • OpenStreetMap



1 National Archives

Thursday 9:30 a.m. • educator-led program, then the Rotunda

The nation's record keeper. The Declaration of Independence, the Constitution and the Bill of Rights are displayed together in the Rotunda on Constitution Avenue.

What we do. Students work with an Archives educator, then compare one founding document with a later civic record for journal prompt 1.

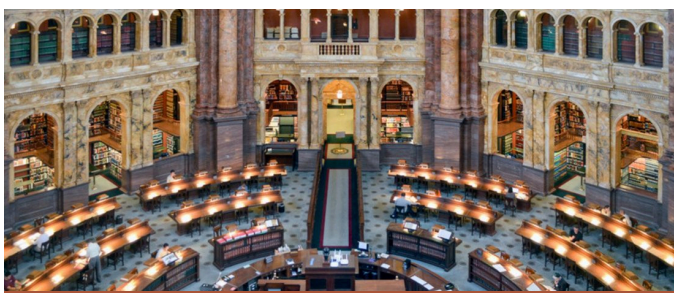


2 U.S. Capitol

Thursday 1:00 p.m. • tour, then Exhibition Hall

Where Congress meets. The tour passes beneath the dome in the Rotunda and through National Statuary Hall; Exhibition Hall shows how a bill becomes law.

What we do. Students map one path from a public concern to a law for journal prompt 2.

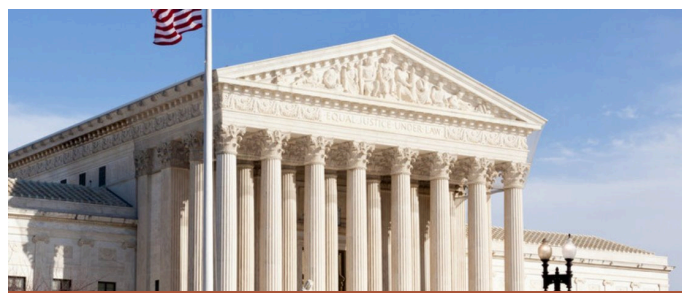


3 Library of Congress

Thursday 2:30 p.m. • Thomas Jefferson Building

The largest library in the world. The Great Hall's marble, mosaics and murals were finished in 1897 to celebrate learning; the Main Reading Room sits under a 160-foot dome.

What we do. Students read the building as a message about knowledge and record one detail with a claim.



4 Supreme Court

Thursday 3:45 p.m. • from the plaza

The nation's highest court, across First Street from the Capitol. The words above the west entrance read Equal Justice Under Law.

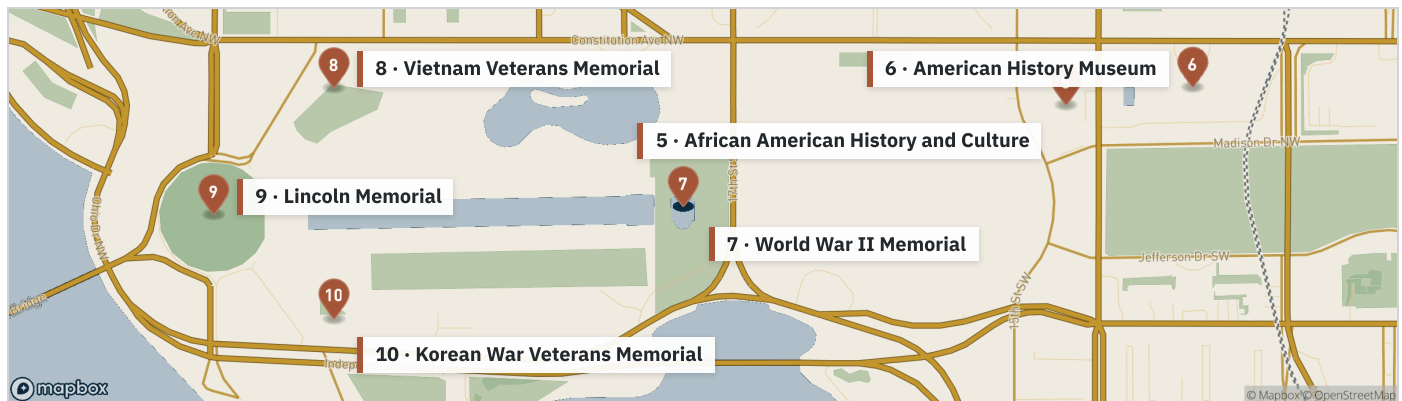
What we do. A 20-minute lesson from the steps on who decides what a law means.



Washington, DC
April 14 to 18, 2027

Friday: Voices, Rights and Public Memory

Two Smithsonian museums on the National Mall by day, then a walk at dusk through four memorials that end at the Lincoln Memorial.



Friday, April 16 • numbered in visit order Mapbox • OpenStreetMap

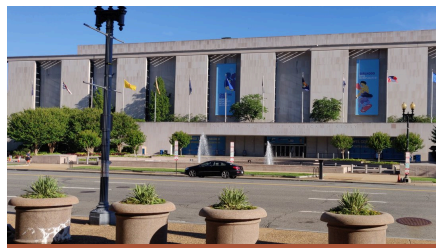


5 National Museum of African American History and Culture

Friday 10:00 a.m. • group entry in three groups of ten

The Smithsonian's newest museum on the Mall, opened in 2016. The History Galleries descend three floors below ground; the Culture and Community Galleries rise above.

What we do. Students follow one person's or one community's story across time for journal prompt 3.



6 National Museum of American History

Friday 2:15 p.m. • self-guided in groups

Home of the Star-Spangled Banner, the flag that flew over Fort McHenry in 1814, and objects from everyday American life across three centuries.

What we do. Students compare two objects that tell different stories about belonging for journal prompt 4.

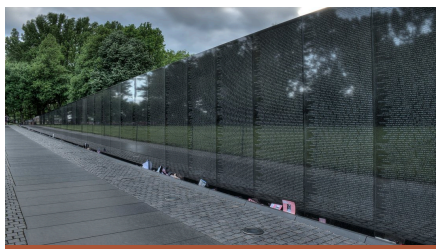


7 World War II Memorial

Friday 6:30 p.m. • first stop of the memorial walk

Fifty-six pillars and two arches around a plaza and fountain, opened in 2004 between the Washington Monument and the Reflecting Pool.

What we do. Students begin the design comparison for journal prompt 5: names, scale, materials, movement, silence.



8 Vietnam Veterans Memorial

Friday evening • on the walk

Maya Lin's wall of polished black granite lists more than 58,000 names in the order they were lost. It opened in 1982.

What we do. Students walk the wall in silence and find one name to record.



9 Lincoln Memorial

Friday evening • on the walk

Lincoln's seated statue looks east down the Reflecting Pool. The Gettysburg Address is carved on the south wall; Martin Luther King Jr. spoke from these steps in 1963.

What we do. Groups read the Gettysburg Address aloud and stand where the 1963 march ended.



10 Korean War Veterans Memorial

Friday evening • last stop; bus at 8:45 p.m.

Nineteen stainless-steel figures walk through juniper toward the flag; the Wall of Remembrance, added in 2022, lists the fallen by name.

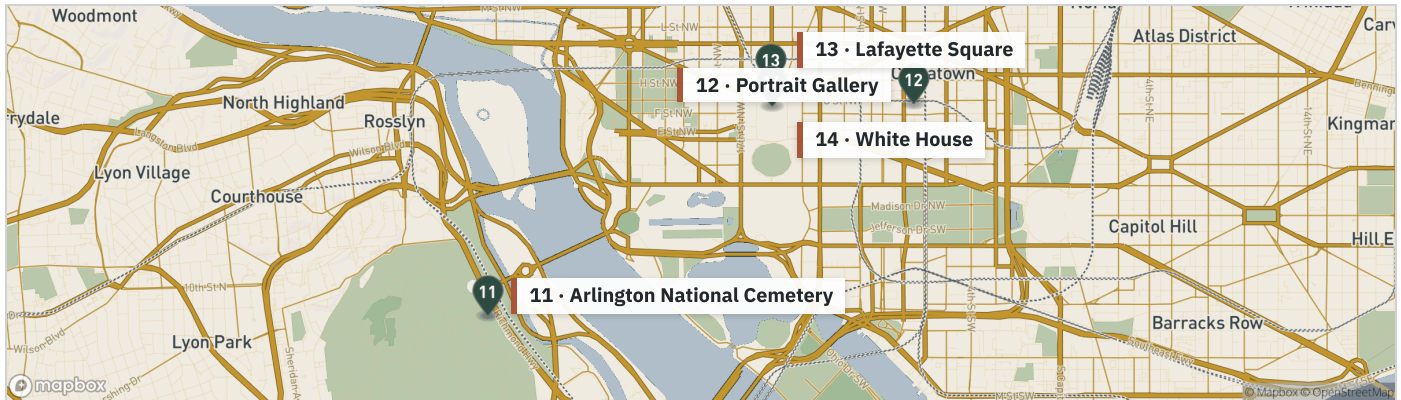
What we do. Students compare this memorial with the Vietnam wall before the bus leaves from Lincoln Memorial Circle.

Saturday: Service, Leadership and Representation



Washington, DC
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Across the Potomac to Arlington in the morning, then portraits of American leaders and the square in front of the White House before the closing seminar and the overnight ride home.



Saturday, April 17 • numbered in visit order Mapbox • OpenStreetMap



11 Arlington National Cemetery

Saturday 8:30 a.m. • walking visit

More than 400,000 service members and their families rest on the hills across the Potomac. The guard at the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier changes every half hour in spring.

What we do. Kennedy gravesite, Memorial Amphitheater and the Tomb; a private reflection for journal prompt 6.



12 National Portrait Gallery

Saturday 1:00 p.m. • self-guided

Portraits of every president in America's Presidents, inside the old Patent Office Building it shares with the Smithsonian American Art Museum.

What we do. Students analyze one leader's portrait for journal prompt 7: pose, setting, symbols and label.

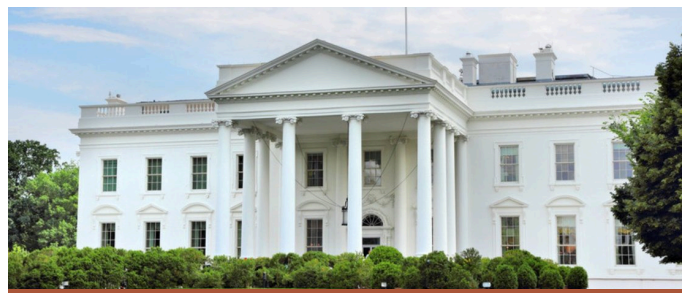


13 Lafayette Square

Saturday 3:15 p.m. • on foot from the gallery

The seven-acre park north of the White House, named for the French general who fought in the Revolution, and a place of protest and gathering for two centuries.

What we do. Students note who is present, what is protected and what is open to view.



14 White House

Saturday afternoon • from Pennsylvania Avenue

The president's home and office since 1800, seen from the north side on Pennsylvania Avenue.

What we do. The last observation note before the closing seminar at the hotel.

Learning by Day

Every site has one task, one idea and one piece of evidence for the journal. Olivia Bennett leads the prompts; every chaperone carries this page.



Washington, DC
April 14 to 18, 2027

SITE	STUDENTS DO	STUDENTS LEARN	EVIDENCE
The journey east	Trace the route in the journal and note how the land, the towns and the roads change between Lake Erie and the Potomac.	A national capital depends on the regions it connects.	Annotated route note
National Archives	Observe one founding document and one later civic record. Identify who wrote it, why, and what it cannot tell us alone.	Democratic claims are preserved, interpreted and contested through evidence.	Primary-source card
U.S. Capitol	Map one path from a public concern to a law: who proposes, who debates, who votes, who signs.	Representation, debate and procedure shape federal lawmaking.	Institution diagram
Library of Congress	Read the building as a message about knowledge. Record one visual detail and what it claims.	Public institutions choose, organize and open access to evidence.	Detail sketch and claim
Supreme Court	From the steps, read the words above the entrance and discuss who decides what a law means.	Interpretation is a separate power from lawmaking.	One-sentence note
African American History and Culture	Follow one person's or one community's story across time; connect an object, a voice and its context.	National history changes when people once excluded are treated as historical actors.	Voice-and-evidence pair
American History	Compare two objects that tell different stories about belonging or citizenship.	Objects carry perspective; a museum's choices shape interpretation.	Object comparison
Memorials	Compare names, scale, materials, movement and silence at two of the four memorials.	Public memory is designed, and the design makes choices about sacrifice, grief and unity.	Design comparison
Arlington	Observe the ritual and the conduct of visitors. Write a private reflection on service and its cost.	Commemoration joins individual lives to national memory.	Private reflection
Portrait Gallery	Analyze pose, setting, symbols and the label text of one leader's portrait.	Portraits construct public identity and show whose leadership is recognized.	Portrait analysis
White House	From Lafayette Square, note who is present, what is protected, and what is open to view.	Executive power is visible, guarded and accountable at the same time.	Observation note
Closing seminar	Use three sites to answer the core question. Challenge one classmate's claim with evidence.	Civic understanding grows through corroboration, perspective and reasoned argument.	Exit claim

Before the trip

In class, March 22 to April 9

Read short excerpts from the Constitution and from one later rights claim.

Write one authentic question to carry to Washington.

Practice the source, object and space routines on Cleveland examples.

Rehearse conduct for memorials, museums and Arlington.

After the trip

Due Friday, April 30

A 500-to-750-word argued response to the core question, or a three-panel civic exhibit pitch with captions and sources.

Evidence from at least three different sites.

One idea that changed, and one question that remains.

Field Journal & Assessment

Short prompts for the field; longer answers continue in the journal. The four-point guide is how the final response is graded.



Washington, DC
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1 • Evidence (National Archives)

Choose one original record. What claim does it make, and what can it not tell us on its own?

2 • Institution (Capitol, Library, Supreme Court)

Where did you see power divided, checked or made visible? Name the evidence.

3 • Voice (African American History and Culture)

Whose story changed or complicated what you thought you knew about U.S. history?

4 • Object (American History)

Which object carried the strongest story? Separate what you observed from what you inferred.

5 • Memory (the memorials)

How did the design of one memorial shape the way you moved, spoke or felt?

6 • Service (Arlington, private)

What did you notice about how people behave here, and what does that say about what is being honored?

7 • Representation (Portrait Gallery)

What does one portrait say about leadership? What is included, and what is left out?

Final synthesis (closing seminar)

Complete the claim with evidence from three sites: *A democracy stays accountable when...*

Four-point assessment guide

Applied to the final response or exhibit pitch

CRITERION	4 • STRONG	3 • SECURE	2 • DEVELOPING	1 • BEGINNING
Evidence	Specific, accurate evidence from three or more sites; sources clearly distinguished.	Relevant evidence from three sites.	General examples or unclear sources.	Few examples; claims unsupported.
Reasoning	Explains how the evidence supports and complicates the claim.	Connects evidence to the claim.	Connections are partial or repetitive.	Mostly summary; reasoning unclear.
Perspective	Compares viewpoints and names what is missing or omitted.	Includes more than one viewpoint.	Mentions difference without analysis.	One viewpoint presented as complete.
Participation	Prepared, respectful, curious and dependable at every site.	Consistently meets expectations.	Needs occasional reminders.	Conduct or participation limits learning.

For chaperones: the journal is a record of observation and thinking, not a scavenger hunt. Give students quiet time after the African American History and Culture galleries, the memorials and Arlington. The Arlington reflection stays private; students still submit the analytical prompts. Final responses are due Friday, April 30, and the class then chooses one Cleveland civic question to investigate with the same routines.